book by Subir Bhaumik—and 'South Asia's most enduring theatre of separatist guerrilla warfare'.[41] The exigencies of managing this instability led to the creation of several new states in the Indian Union. Nagaland was created in 1963, Meghalaya and Manipur in 1972, Mizoram and Arunachal Pradesh in 1987.[42] Sikkim (previously an autonomous monarchy) merged with India in 1975.

The region has the highest number of tribes anywhere in India and among the most diverse group of languages and sub-languages. It is home to as many as 121 Scheduled Tribes, with multiple sub-tribes.[43] An early Indian Census counted as many as 192 languages and dialects.[44] Added to this was the tyranny of distance: Partition cut off old rail links between the Northeast and the rest of India, which were only revived with the construction of the Takilagram–Siliguri rail link in 1950.[45] It is this diversity and complexity of the Northeast, so far removed from the politics of the Hindi heartland, that makes the BJP's rise all the more remarkable.

The BJP in the Northeast Is Very Different from the BJP in Hindi-speaking States: Cow Politics, Food Habits and Strategic Adaptability

Nothing illustrates the BJP's strategic adaptability in the Northeast more than its approach to the cow question. On the Narad Index, we compared all Facebook posts by BJP chief ministers, as well as BJP handles, in the eight north-eastern states versus all Facebook posts by their counterparts in UP, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Bihar over a two-year period: 2017–2019. We found that, while BJP leaders in the Hindi heartland focus a great deal on cows, cow-welfare and related issues, there are virtually no mentions of it on BJP handles in the Northeast, where large sections of the population eat beef (see Figure 16.4). When issues related to cows did feature (like they did on occasion in Arunachal or Tripura), they were in response to controversies over beef-eating or cow-protection in the Hindi-speaking states. In these states, BJP chief ministers like Vasundhara Raje (Rajasthan chief minister: 2013–2018, 2003–2008) and Yogi Adityanath of UP (in his 2019-20 budget) earmarked